

The Manual MVP

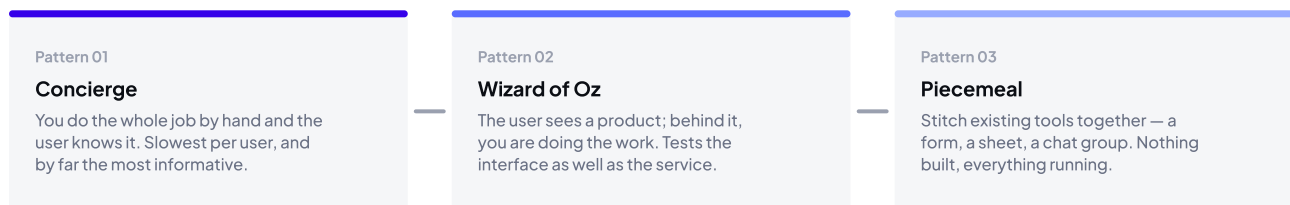
Thirty days, ten real users, and no product. Deliver the service by hand first — it is faster, it teaches you more, and it is the version you can afford to be wrong about.



The first version should be a person, not a product.

Almost everything you need to learn in the first month is about what people actually want done, in what order, and what they will tolerate. None of that requires software. All of it is obscured by building software, because building takes long enough that you stop asking.

A manual first version is not a lesser version. It is a different instrument, built to answer a different question. Software answers “can this scale”. A person with a notebook answers “does anybody want this” — which is the question you actually have.



Most first months should be concierge. The other two are what you move to once you know what the job actually is.

Three ways to run a product that does not exist. They differ in how much the user can see, not in how real the service is. In all three, somebody genuinely gets their problem solved.

What this is not

This is not a landing page with a waiting list. A page measures curiosity. A manual service measures whether the thing you would build actually helps — and it produces a customer, which a page never does.

Cut it until one person can run it in a day

The most common failure of a manual first version is that it is still too big. If you cannot personally deliver it for ten people using hours you actually have, it is not scoped yet. Cut scope, not quality: serve fewer people, in a smaller place, solving a narrower slice.

CUT THESE

Anyone outside one neighbourhood, campus or building

Every feature that is not the one they described

Payments, until somebody has asked to pay

Accounts, logins, dashboards and settings

Everything that only matters at a hundred users

KEEP THESE

The one thing that goes wrong for them today

A way for them to reach you that they already use

A record of what you did for each person

The promise you made about when it would be done

A way for them to come back tomorrow

Scope is subtraction. Everything in the left column is work that will be needed eventually and teaches you nothing this month.

Worksheet 1 · The manual service spec

BEFORE DAY ONE

One page. If it does not fit, it is not scoped.

The one job you are doing for people, in a sentence

Who exactly — how would you recognise an eligible person?

Narrow is good. "Students in one faculty" beats "students".

How they ask you for it

Use a channel they already have open. A WhatsApp number beats an app.

What you do, step by step, by hand

Write every step. This list becomes the specification if you ever build it.

What they get, and by when

A promise with a time in it. This is the only thing you must not break.

The hours per user this will cost you

Multiply by ten. If that number is larger than your month, cut again.

Two users a week, then everything at once

THIRTY DAYS

Scope and set up					days 1–4
Write the spec, open the channel, tell nobody yet.					
First two users					days 5–9
Deliberately over-serve them. Learn where the job really is.					
Rewrite the spec					days 10–11
You will be wrong about at least one step. Fix it before scaling the error.					
Users three to ten					days 12–25
Two a week. Log every delivery on the day it happens.					
Hold and watch					days 26–29
Stop recruiting. See who comes back without being asked.					
Decide					day 30
Build, change, or stop — against the numbers, not the feeling.					

Thirty days, six phases. The hold in the last week is the most valuable part and the part founders skip: a service nobody returns to while you are still pushing it has told you something.

Over-serve the first two, deliberately

Do things that could never scale. Deliver it personally, on a Friday, at their office. You are not testing the economics this month — you are finding out what the job actually is, and the only way to find that is to do it all yourself once.

One row per delivery, on the day

This log is the difference between a month of favours and a month of evidence. It is also the specification for whatever you build next: every step you performed by hand is a step the software will have to perform, and every step you kept skipping is one it will not.

COLUMN	WHAT GOES IN IT
Date	The day you delivered, not the day they asked.
Who	Name or initials.
What they asked for	In their words, not your categories.
What you actually did	Every step, including the ones you improvised.
Time it took you	Honestly. This is your future unit cost.
What went wrong	Something always does. This is the most useful column.
Did they come back?	And whether you had to ask them to.

Delivery log · rows 1–4

COPY THIS PAGE THREE TIMES

1. Date · Who · Asked for · Time taken

What I did, and what went wrong

2. Date · Who · Asked for · Time taken

What I did, and what went wrong

3. Date · Who · Asked for · Time taken

What I did, and what went wrong

Existence is use by somebody else

There is a ladder here, and knowing which rung you are on is worth more than moving up it quickly. Most first-time founders describe themselves two rungs above where they actually are, which is why readers of applications discount what they are told.

REAL

People came back without being asked

The only rung that predicts anything. Everything below it can be produced by effort and goodwill.

Ten people used it, once

Real, countable, and enough for an application. This is the target for thirty days.

Two people used it

A pilot. Informative for you, not yet evidence for anyone else.

It works, and only you have used it

A demo. Common, and routinely described as an MVP.

It is designed and described

A document. Nothing has been tested yet.

CLAIMED

Where you actually are. Find your rung honestly. A founder who says “two people used it, and neither came back” is more credible than one who says “we have an MVP”, and is treated accordingly.

Worksheet 2 · The thirty-day decision

DAY THIRTY

People who used it at least once

People who came back without being asked

The number that matters. Zero is a finding, not a failure.

Median time it took you per delivery

The step that broke most often

This is the first thing worth automating, and possibly the only thing.

What you would build, now, in one sentence — and what you no longer would

Build, change the service, or stop

The one thing to automate first

Not the thing that is most interesting to build. The step in your log that broke most often, or took longest. If those are different steps, take the one that broke — slow is survivable, broken is not.

MISSION 01



09

13

MISSION 15

Where this sits. Missions 09 and 13. The delivery log from this month is the input to Mission 14 and to **Toolkit 04 — The Demand Signal**.

Nothing in this toolkit requires you to write code, register a company, or spend money. If your version of it does, the scope is still too big — go back to Worksheet 1 and cut again.



StartPad tells you the truth about whether you are ready, gets you ready, and gives you the proof.

What it is

A founder-readiness platform for Egypt and the wider MENA region. It takes a young person who has an idea and no company, moves them through fifteen structured missions, and turns them into someone the ecosystem will take seriously — then issues verifiable proof of that.

It is not a course platform, not an education brand and not a youth club. Nothing here is graded. Every mission ends in an artefact you own.

Three moves, always in this order

TRUTH Where you actually stand

Measured against what programmes actually ask for, stated plainly, before any encouragement.

READINESS Fifteen structured missions

They close the specific gaps the assessment found, in the order that matters. A route, not a curriculum.

PROOF A verifiable credential

The ecosystem can check it without asking you. You apply with a file, not a hope.

On your idea

StartPad earns when a founder gets into somewhere — an accelerator, a programme, a room. Taking a founder's idea would end that. Work submitted to a mission is sealed and timestamped to the person who submitted it, and the seal is the product.

Nothing in this document asks you to give anything up to use it. It is yours to fill in, print, and hand to whoever needs to see it.

startpad.me

Start with the readiness assessment. It is free and it takes about twenty minutes.